

Views and effects

Flex applications define view states as particular presentations of a visual component. In each moment of the user's interactions with the application, each visual component presents itself in a particular form known as its current view state. Flex enables you to define as many different view states as you like for the Application and for each of its custom MXML components using declarative code, and then enables you to switch easily between states by setting the Application or custom component's `currentState` property. View state management in Flex is designed primarily for application scenarios where the Application or component uses a significant portion of its presentation in multiple situations and makes incremental changes to its presentation for each new situation. This sort of incremental change is different from application navigation, where the user moves between multiple different layers, or views, that don't share content with each other. In Flex 4.5, you always declare view states in MXML. In Flex 3, you could also use ActionScript code to declare view states, but the resulting code was verbose and difficult to maintain. Even further, the MXML view state code has been dramatically altered since Flex 3, resulting in much cleaner MXML declarations.

When you switch view states at runtime, you can make the change abruptly or, using transitions, you can choreograph the change with ActionScript-based effects. A transition is a class that enables you to easily associate effects with view state changes. View states are used to define incremental changes to an existing view. For example, a login form that initially requests a user name and password can, with the addition of a few more controls, also be used as a registration form. Any visual objects you declare are by default included in the form's initial presentation. To create different versions of the form, you declare new view states with unique names.

View states are declared with MXML code. You can either code a view state manually or, using Flash Builder's Design mode, generate the required code based on changes you make to a component at design time. View states are identified by creating new State objects and setting their name property, which is a String value that you assign in MXML code. Each visual component that's displayed on the screen in a Flex application has an initial view state that's named by default `State1`. The default state is defined by all the object's current property and style settings, event handlers, and in the case of containers, nested child components in its display list, and it's represented by the main MXML in the document.

In Flex 4.5, the default value of the current State property is the name of